

MetaHOPE: News Metaphor Translation Annotation Guideline 2.0

Annotator Version

1. Annotation Task

Objective

This annotation task evaluates the translation quality of metaphorical expressions in news translation.

Note: Only the highlighted metaphorical expressions are evaluated.

- Source metaphorical expressions are shown in bold and underlined in the source text.

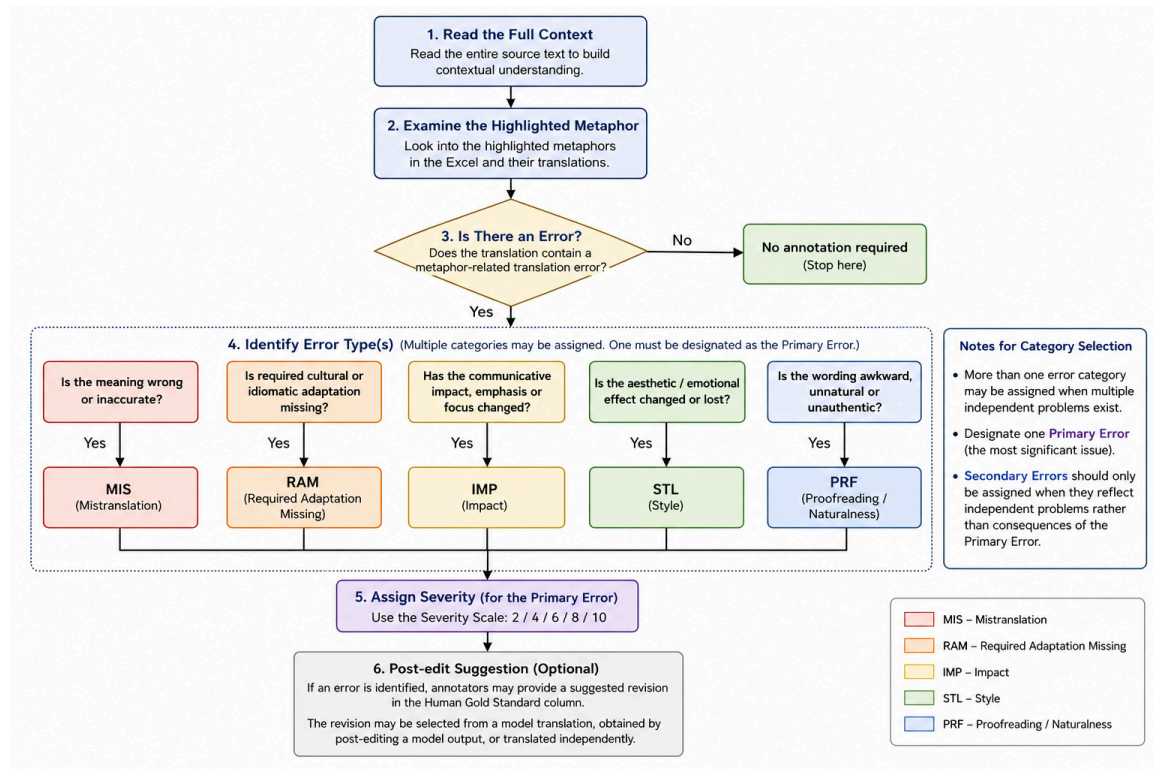
钱老师连连摆手：“论苦心大是周彤，为迎接竞赛做题三千多道，草稿纸堆起来只怕比他人还高。”

- Their corresponding translations are already marked in bold and underlined in the target text.

Teacher Qian waved his hands repeatedly, "Zhou Tong has put in the most effort. To prepare for the competition, he did over three thousand problems; the pile of draft paper is probably taller than everyone else's."

- Annotators should evaluate only these highlighted metaphorical expressions. And the rest of the sentence is provided only for context and should not be evaluated.

2. Annotation Procedure (updated)



Step 1: Read the Full Context (texts are in the folder and are named with docid)

Read the entire article to understand the overall topic, discourse context, communicative purpose, and intended meaning of the metaphor.

Step 2: Determine Whether an Error Exists

Question: Does the translation contain a metaphor-related translation error?

Options:

- No Error
- Error

If no error is identified, no further annotation is required.

Step 3: Identify Error Type(s) (See below)

If an error exists, select the applicable error category or categories from the framework below.

If multiple independent errors are present, multiple categories may be assigned.

For each annotated instance, it can be one error type, or multiple error types, e.g. MIS and IMP. Assign the corresponding error severity levels for all possible error types, wherever needed.

Step 4: Assign Severity

Assign a severity score to each error type that you selected. (2,4,6,8,10): using the severity scale (Section 5 for more details).

Step 5: Produce a human gold standard reference; can use post-editing or totally from your own.

(See below) [p.s. The generated multiple references from the same source can be valuable multi-reference parallel corpus for MT evaluation. Higher impact.]

If an error is identified, annotators may provide a suggested revision in the Human Gold Standard column. The revision may be either selected from one of the model translations or produced by post-editing one of the model outputs.

3. Decision Rules (updated)

A translation may contain more than one error category. Annotators may assign multiple error labels when the translation exhibits multiple independent problems.

However, **each annotated translation may have one Primary Error type**, representing the most significant problem affecting the quality of the metaphor translation. Additional categories may be assigned as **Secondary Error types** when appropriate if there is the primary error. Otherwise, they might be parallel, without primary/secondary types.

When selecting the Primary Error type (if this situation occurs), use the following principles:

- MIS should be selected as the Primary Error type whenever the intended metaphorical meaning is incorrect or cannot be recovered.
- RAM should be the Primary Error type when the intended meaning is preserved but a required target-language metaphorical, idiomatic, or cultural adaptation is missing.
- IMP should be the Primary Error type when the intended meaning is preserved but the communicative impact is substantially altered.
- STL should be the Primary Error type when the intended meaning and communicative impact are preserved but the stylistic realization of the metaphor is not appropriate.
- PRF should be selected as the Primary Error type only when the remaining issue is limited to fluency or naturalness.

Secondary Error types should only be assigned when they reflect independent translation problems rather than consequences of the Primary Error type.

4. Error Categories (updated)

IMP (Impact)

An Impact Error occurs when the translation conveys the basic meaning of a metaphor but fails to preserve its intended **communicative impact, such as its persuasive force, emotional effect, evaluative stance, or emphasis**, thereby producing a substantially weaker or different effect on the target audience (Steen, 2017; Gladkoff & Han, 2022; Schäffner, 2004).

Example 1 (EN-ZH):

EN: Officials ***lashed out*** at the decision.

ZH: 官员对这一决定 ***表示不满*** (gloss: Officials ***expressed dissatisfaction*** at the decision.)

-> suggest translation: 官员 ***强烈抨击*** 这一决定 (gloss: strongly attack)

Explanation:

The translation preserves the basic meaning but weakens the metaphorical force. While *lashed out* conveys a forceful verbal attack, *表示不满* merely expresses dissatisfaction, reducing the persuasive force and rhetorical impact. The meaning is retained, but the communicative impact of the metaphor is weakened, resulting in an Impact Error.

Example 2 (ZH-EN):

ZH: 该公司***裁减***了上千个岗位。 (gloss: The company ***cut*** thousands of jobs.)

EN: *Thousands of jobs **were cut**.*

-> *suggest translation:* The company **slashed** thousands of jobs.

Explanation:

The translation preserves the basic meaning but shifts the communicative emphasis. By changing the focus from the company as the responsible actor to the affected jobs, it foregrounds the consequence rather than the action. The intended rhetorical emphasis is therefore altered, resulting in an Impact Error.

**Note:*

A change in voice (e.g., active vs. passive) should not be treated as an Impact Error unless it substantially alters the intended communicative emphasis or rhetorical effect of the metaphor.

RAM (Required Adaptation Missing)

A Required Adaptation Missing (RAM) Error occurs when a source metaphor requires **adaptation to target-language metaphorical, idiomatic, or cultural norms**, but the necessary adaptation is not made (Gladkoff & Han, 2022; Kövecses, 2010; Newmark, 1988).

EN: The plan has gained **momentum** in recent weeks.

ZH: 该计划在最近几周获得了**动量**。(gloss: The plan has gained **momentum** in recent weeks)

-> *suggest translation:* 该计划在最近几周**势头**上涨 (gloss: momentum)

Explanation:

The translation preserves the intended meaning but does not adopt the conventional metaphorical expression used in Chinese news discourse. Chinese news reports conventionally use 势头 (upward momentum or gaining strength) to describe increasing progress or development. By contrast, 获得了动量 (gained momentum) is a literal rendering of the English expression that is not idiomatic in Chinese. The required adaptation to target-language metaphorical convention is therefore missing, resulting in a Required Adaptation Missing Error.

ZH: 该政策给经济发展**注入了一针强心剂**。(gloss: The policy **gave** the economy **a much-needed boost**.)

EN: The policy **boosted** the economy.

-> *suggest translation:* The policy gave the economy **a much-needed shot in the arm**.

Explanation:

The translation preserves the intended meaning but omits the conventional English metaphor. English commonly uses a shot in the arm to express renewed strength or encouragement, whereas boosted the economy paraphrases the

meaning without preserving the established metaphorical expression. The required target-language adaptation is therefore missing, resulting in a RAM Error.

MIS (Mistranslation)

A Mistranslation Error occurs when the translation distorts the intended meaning of the source metaphor, resulting in an accuracy error and a different semantic interpretation in the target text. This typically occurs because the **metaphorical interpretation, conceptual mapping, or contextual meaning is not correctly transferred** (Gladkoff & Han 2022; Lakoff & Johnson, 1980; Schäffner, 2004; Kövecses, 2010).

EN: The company is *on its last legs* after years of losses.

ZH: 该公司在多年亏损后正处于它的最后几条腿上。(literal translation: *on its last legs*)

-> suggest translation: 该公司在多年亏损后正处于倒闭边缘 (gloss: The company is *on the edge of bankruptcy* after years of losses.)

Explanation:

The source metaphor maps physical weakness (last legs) onto impending failure. This conceptual mapping is not preserved in the literal Chinese translation, which instead prompts a literal interpretation and fails to convey the intended metaphorical meaning.

ZH: 他总喜欢给别人穿小鞋。(gloss: *He always makes other people wear small shoes i.e., deliberately makes things difficult for them.*)

EN: He always makes people *wear small shoes*.

-> suggest translation: He always *makes life difficult* for other people.

Explanation:

The Chinese idiom “穿小鞋 (wear small shoes)” is a conventional metaphor meaning to deliberately create difficulties for someone or treat them unfairly. The English translation interprets the expression literally as *making people wear small shoes*, rather than conveying its intended metaphorical meaning. As a result, the metaphorical interpretation is lost, producing a different semantic interpretation and resulting in a Mistranslation Error.

STL (Style)

A Style Error occurs when the translation preserves the metaphor's basic referential meaning but alters the stylistic realization of the metaphor: **register, tenor, voice, figurative vividness, or genre-appropriate rhetorical effect**, thereby performing a different expressive

or interpersonal function from the source (Newmark, 1988; House, 2015; Boase-Beier, 2020; Dorst, 2019).

Example:

EN: The market has slipped into a casino atmosphere.

ZH: 市场变得投机性越来越强。 (gloss: The market has become increasingly speculative.)

->suggest translation: 市场充斥着赌场般的投机氛围。 (gloss: The market is filled with a casino-like speculative atmosphere.)

Explanation:

The translation “投机性 (speculative)” preserves the intended meaning of “casino” but paraphrases the metaphor into a neutral expression, resulting in the loss of its figurative imagery and rhetorical style. Since metaphor serves both semantic and stylistic functions, such cases can be classified as Style Errors when the meaning is retained but the metaphorical expression is not.

ZH: 市场出现明显回暖。 (gloss: The market has shown a clear warming trend.)

EN: The market rose like a phoenix from the ashes.

->suggest translation: The market showed clear signs of recovery.

Explanation:

The translation “rose like a phoenix from the ashes” conveys part of the meaning of “回暖(market) recovery” but adopts a highly literary and fictional metaphor that is stylistically inappropriate for the news genre. Although the propositional meaning is preserved, the target text shifts from an objective journalistic style to a poetic narrative voice, resulting in a Style Error.

PRF (Proofreading / Naturalness)

A Proofreading / Naturalness Error occurs when the metaphor is translated with basically correct meaning and appropriate metaphorical interpretation, but **the target expression is awkward or unnatural**. The error affects the fluency or acceptability of the translation rather than meaning transfer (Gladkoff & Han, 2022; Baker, 1992).

Example:

EN: Inflation is eating into household incomes.

ZH: 通货膨胀正在吃进家庭收入。 (gloss: Inflation is eating into household incomes.)

-> *suggest translation*: 通货膨胀正在侵蚀家庭收入。(gloss: Inflation is **eroding** household income.)

Explanation:

The translation preserves both the intended meaning and the metaphorical interpretation of the source expression. However, the wording “吃进 (eat into)” is awkward and does not conform to natural Chinese usage. A professional translation would more naturally express this idea as “侵蚀 (erode)”, improving fluency and acceptability without changing the underlying meaning or metaphorical interpretation. The problem therefore lies in target-language naturalness rather than meaning transfer, resulting in a Proofreading Error.

ZH: 她决定跳槽到一家更有活力的初创公司。(gloss: She decided to jump trough to a more dynamic startup ie, change jobs for a better opportunity.)

EN: She decided to **jump trough** to a more dynamic startup.

-> *suggest translation*: She decided to **switch jobs** to a more dynamic startup.

Explanation:

The translation “jump trough” conveys the intended meaning of “跳槽(jump trough i.e. changing jobs for a better opportunity)” and preserves the underlying metaphorical interpretation. However, “jump trough” is an awkward and unnatural expression in English, although its intended meaning can be inferred from the literal wording. Although the propositional meaning is preserved, the target expression requires only linguistic refinement rather than a change in meaning, resulting in a Proofreading Error.

5. Severity Scale (updated)

0- no error (can leave the excel corresponding cell empty as it is)

2 – Minor

A minor issue that has little impact on the overall translation. The metaphor remains largely successful.

4 – Moderate

A noticeable error that partially affects the translation quality or metaphor realization, but the overall message remains clear.

6 – Major

A substantial error that clearly weakens the translation. The metaphorical meaning, function, stylistic effect, or naturalness is significantly affected and requires revision.

8 – Severe

A serious error that causes major loss or distortion of the metaphor's intended meaning, function, stylistic effect, or naturalness.

10 – Critical

A critical error that results in failure of metaphor translation. The intended metaphorical meaning, function, stylistic effect, or naturalness in the target-language realization is largely lost or seriously misleading.

6. Pilot Annotation

Annotators first complete a pilot annotation of 20 instances.

Disagreements are discussed and the guideline is refined, if necessary, before formal annotation begins.

Inter-annotator agreement is calculated after the pilot stage and again after the main annotation stage.

7. Annotator Requirements (updated) – pls reach out if you do not meet the requirement for further discussion.

Annotators should have a background in translation, and should meet at least two of the following qualifications:

- CATTI Level 2 or above
- MTI or MA Translation Studies training
- Professional translation experience
- Equivalent academic expertise in translation

Knowledge of metaphor translation is desirable but not required.

Reference:

Liang, Jiahui, and Lifeng Han. "MetaHOPE: A Metaphor-Oriented Evaluation Framework for Analysing MT and LLM Translation Errors." *arXiv preprint arXiv:2607.00848* (2026).

Bibtex:

@article{liang2026metahope,

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title={MetaHOPE: A Metaphor-Oriented Evaluation Framework for Analysing MT and LLM  
Translation Errors},  
author={Liang, Jiahui and Han, Lifeng},  
journal={arXiv preprint arXiv:2607.00848},  
year={2026}  
}
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News:

MetaHOPE is accepted by the CLIN conference 2026 to be presented in Belgium.

The CLIN conference in 2026—the 36th Meeting of Computational Linguistics in the Netherlands—will be presented in Brussels, Belgium. Hosted by the VUB Artificial Intelligence Laboratory, it marks the first time the prestigious annual meeting is taking place in Brussels. September 11th, 2026.

<https://clin36.ai.vub.ac.be/>